

Forests, Lakes, and Prairies



THE EVERGREEN FORESTS OF CANADA consist of dense areas of spruce, pine, and fir trees. These forests are marshy underfoot, with many lakes. Farther south, forests of oak, hickory, and chestnut trees once spread across the eastern part of North America, but today, vast areas have been destroyed for lumber or farming. Some forest animals, such as the raccoon and the opossum, have adapted to this new environment, but many have declined in number or retreated to the hills. The prairies once formed a huge sea of grass. Millions of bison and pronghorn antelope once grazed there, but they were almost wiped out by hunters in the 19th century.

Sage grouse
(*Centrocercus urophasianus*)
Length: up to 30 in (76 cm)



Sage smells

The sage grouse feeds on the leaves of the sagebrush plant. Eventually its flesh takes on a strong sage flavor. During the spring, the male puts on a special display to win a mate. He puffs out his chest feathers, opens and closes his tail, and inflates the air sacs on his neck, which make loud booming, popping noises.

Big cheeks

The least chipmunk has large cheek pouches, which it uses to carry food back to its underground burrow. Inside the burrow are chambers used for storing food, living, and nesting. During winter, the chipmunk hibernates in its home.



Two-spotted ladybug
(*Adalia bipunctata*)
Length: up to 0.25 in (6 mm)

Pest control

The two-spotted ladybug is common throughout North America and can be found in forests, fields, and gardens. It feeds on small insects and helps keep down the number of pests in gardens and fields. The ladybug's hard, red wing cases protect its soft wings and body underneath.

Raccoon
(*Procyon lotor*)
Body length:
up to 2 ft (62 cm)
Tail: up to 14 in (36 cm)



Trash raider

The raccoon has long, sensitive fingers that it uses to search for food. It often comes into cities and raids trash cans for leftover food scraps. The raccoon's thick fur coat keeps it warm during cold winter months.

Least chipmunk
(*Tamias minimus*)
Body length: up to 4.5 in (11.4 cm)
Tail: up to 3.3 in (8.5 cm)



Moose (*Alces alces*)
Height at shoulder: up to 6 ft 10 in (2.1 m)
Length: up to 10 ft 4 in (3.2 m)

Heavyweight deer

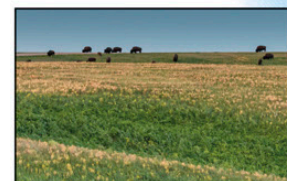
The moose is the largest deer in the world. In the fall, a male may weigh more than 1,000 lbs (450 kg). The moose's broad hooves and long legs help it travel through deep snow, bogs, or lakes. Its overhanging top lip enables the moose to tear off leaves and branches. The male uses his antlers to fight other males and win mates.



Whooping crane
(*Grus americana*)
Height: up to 5 ft 3 in (1.6 m)
Wingspan: up to 7 ft 6 in (2.3 m)

Bugle bird

Named for its bugle-like call, the whooping crane nests only in a remote area of northwest Canada. By the 1940s it had been almost wiped out by hunting. It is now a protected species.



Today the flat plains of the prairies are used for growing wheat.



The forest lakes are home to many water birds, including gulls, ducks, and swans.